
Foundation Certificate in Higher Education

DOC 330: Designing Innovative Solutions

Tutorial 2 - Design Thinking

Learn from Observing

A fundamental principle of innovation or creative thinking is to start with empathy. On the path from blank page to insight, sometimes people need a tool to help with what comes next: synthesis. You've gone into the field in search of knowledge, meeting people on their home turf, watching and listening intently. But synthesizing all that data can be a little daunting. Take control of your field observations by organizing them with an "empathy Map."

Tool: Empathy Maps

Participants: Designing Innovative Solutions: Session 1 -allocated group members

Instructions:

1. Draw a 4-quadrant map. Label the sections with "say," "do," "think, " and "feel, " respectively.
2. Populate the left-hand quadrants with Post-its that capture each of your individual observations, using one Post-it per idea. Place observations about what people DO in the lower-left quadrant, and place observations of what people SAY in the upper-left quadrant. Try color-coding your observations, using green Post-its for positive things, yellow Post-its for neutral, and pink or red for frustrations, confusion, or pain points. The key is not to record everything, but instead to capture what stands out.

3. When you run out of observations on the left side, begin to fill the right side with Post-its, inferring what people THINK in the upper-right quadrant and what they FEEL in the lower-right quadrant. Pay attention to people's body language, tone, and choice of words.
4. Take a step back and look at the map as a whole. Try to draw some insights or conclusions from what you have just written down, shared, and talked about. These questions serve as a good prompt for a discussion of insights. What seems new or surprising? Are there contradictions or disconnects within or between quadrants? What unexpected patterns appear? What, if any, latent human needs emerge?